Share Our Wealth

Sen. Huey P. Long (D-LA) · national radio address · February 23, 1934 · excerpts

Source: U.S. Senate Historical Office, senate.gov; Long Papers, LSU Libraries.

Louisiana's flamboyant senator launched the Share Our Wealth Society from a radio studio in 1934 with the slogan 'Every Man a King.' Long proposed capping personal wealth at $5 million, guaranteeing every family a $5,000 'household estate,' and providing pensions, free college, and a 30-hour work week. By 1935 the society claimed 7.5 million members in 27,000 local clubs. Long was assassinated in September 1935 before he could mount a planned 1936 third-party challenge to FDR — but the pressure from his movement pushed FDR's 'Second New Deal' (Social Security, the Wagner Act, the Wealth Tax Act).

Connect: The Second New Deal (1935: Social Security, Wagner Act, Wealth Tax) was partly a response to pressure from Huey Long and others. Show how left-wing pressure moved FDR leftward.

Key Passages

The diagnosis

> We have in America today more wealth, more goods, more food, more clothing, more houses than we have ever had. … The trouble is that we have too much. … We have everything our people need to make them comfortable, contented, and happy. But the rule has been established that some control everything and the rest of the people control nothing.

The plan

> We have to limit large fortunes. … Then we have to make a redistribution of those fortunes. Then we have to provide for every family the necessities of life — a home, comforts, education for the children, and at least sufficient old-age pension.

'Every man a king'

> Every man a king. Every man a king. So that there will not be anyone who is not a king. Sure, that may sound radical. But I am for redistributing wealth so that there is no more poverty.

HAPP Analysis

Model answers fill the first three rows. Use them to explain the author's Purpose in the last row.

HAPP Element	Your Analysis
Historical Context *What was happening when this was written?*	The Great Depression; many Americans felt FDR's early New Deal had not done enough for the poor, as inequality and unemployment remained high.
Intended Audience *Who was the source written for?*	Ordinary, struggling Americans listening on radio nationwide, especially the poor and working class who might join Share Our Wealth clubs.
Point of View *Whose perspective? Whose is missing?*	Huey Long, a populist Louisiana senator and political rival of FDR, who used radical promises to build national support.

HAPP Element	Your Analysis
Purpose *What did the author want to accomplish?*	

Analysis Prompts

1. DBQ Complexity (1 pt): Argue both how Long PUSHED the New Deal leftward AND how he competed with FDR for the same voters.

2. Identify TWO specific New Deal measures of 1935 that responded to pressure from Long and other left critics.

3. Was Long a populist, a demagogue, or both? Defend your answer.